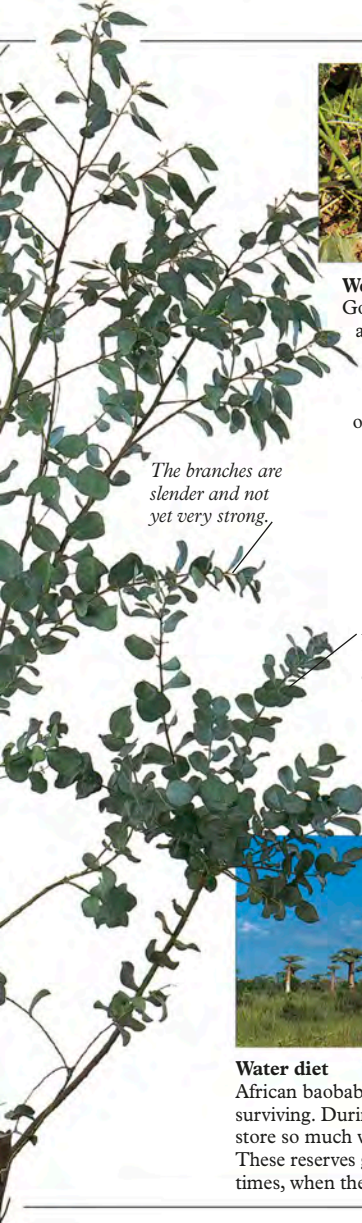
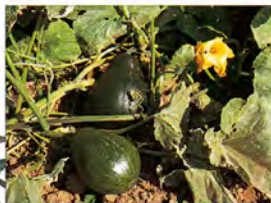




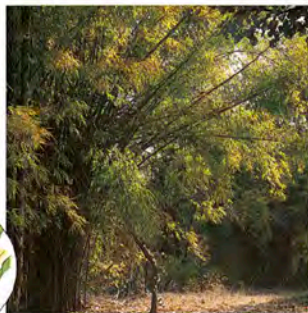
The branches are slender and not yet very strong.



Weak at the knees

Gourd stems don't even attempt to stand up to support their fruit, which may weigh several pounds. They just trail gracefully over the ground.

The inside of a bamboo cane is hollow.



Food is made in the leaves and travels down to the roots.

Keep off!

It is very difficult to get near a prickly thistle, but most animals that do won't be back for a second bite.



Close-up of thistle stem



Water diet

African baobab trees have a special way of surviving. During the rainy season their trunks store so much water that they visibly swell up. These reserves get them through the hot, dry times, when their slimmer shape slowly returns.

Section through cactus



Conservation

Desert cacti hold water reserves in their thick stems. Thirsty animals know that. But the barricade of fierce spines means no free drinks.

